WORKING WITH AGENT SKILLS · O'REILLY · LUCAS SOARES

Ten patterns, *one week*

The week you already have, run differently.

THE PREMISE

Monday morning, something lands on your desk

You own it. It ships Friday.

Whatever your job is

- A feature to launch

The week has the same shape

Talk, decide, build, check, ship, hand off.

Each of those steps has a pattern attached to it now. That is what we are cataloguing today.

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- A campaign to run
- A migration to finish

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"Work primitives are the smallest repeatable workflow units where the friction of manual execution has finally dissolved."

Chapter 4, the definition we're working from

THE MAP

Ten patterns, five days

Monday
Brain dumping · the one document

Tuesday
Composability

Wednesday
Reactions · priors · note-OS

Thursday
Hoarding · fixing the spec

Friday
The HTML lens · the handoff

BEFORE WE START

The pieces on the table

SKILL.md

A folder with instructions. The agent loads it when it decides the folder is relevant. Same format in Claude Code, Codex, Cursor and Gemini CLI.

Prompt

One shot. Dies with the session.

Memory file

Facts that are true every session.

Connector / MCP

Reaches into a live system.

Subagent

A worker with its own context window. Runs in parallel and reports back.

Which one, when

	Use it when	If you pick wrong
Prompt	You will do it once	You retype it forever
SKILL.md	It has steps and makes a file	A folder nobody opens
Memory file	It is true every session	Context bloat
Connector	The data lives elsewhere	Setup you never use
Subagent	It is slow and independent	Coordination overhead

THAT IS THE WHOLE TAXONOMY. WE ARE DONE WITH IT.

BEFORE WE START · WHY SKILLS SCALE

Progressive disclosure

Level	What loads	When	Cost
1	`name` + `description`	Always, at startup	~100 tokens per skill
2	The SKILL.md body	When the skill triggers	Under ~5k tokens
3	`references/`, `scripts/`, `assets/`	When the agent reads or runs them	Zero until used

INSTALL FIFTY SKILLS AND PAY FOR ONE. SKILL.MD IS THE MAP, THE FOLDER IS THE TERRITORY.

A SKILL, IN FULL

```
---
name: meeting-to-tasks
description: Turn a meeting recording into filed notes and tasks.
---

1. Transcribe the recording
2. Extract decisions, owners, deadlines
3. Write the note to the project folder
4. Push open items to the task manager
```

Markdown and a folder. Now let's run your week.

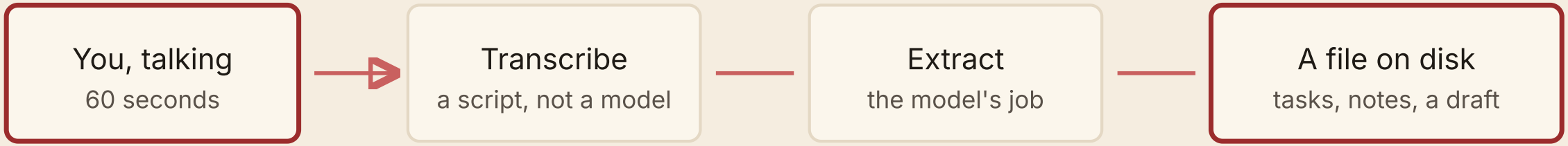
MONDAY, 8:40AM

You know what to do.

You just haven't *written it down*.

PATTERN 1 · BRAIN DUMPING

Talk first, structure never



You no longer have to be organised to produce organised output.

PATTERN 1 · IN THE WILD

Three sizes of the same move

1

Granola takes the live transcript and returns follow-up emails per owner, queued Slack messages, extracted actionables

50

Interview transcripts in, a CSV and a dashboard out

4h → 15m

Interview recordings compressed straight into roadmap decision files

DEMO · MONDAY

```
$ claude "process my latest voice memo"

  ⎿  transcribe ~/memos/2026-09-01.m4a --process
  ⎿  wrote  ~/notes/week-plan.md
  ⎿  created 6 tasks, 2 with deadlines
```

The transcription is a script. Everything after it is the model.

RECAP · MONDAY MORNING

Brain dumping

The shape

Unstructured speech in. A file on disk out.

The unit of work is now having the thought. The formatting is somebody else's problem.

You need it if

- You put off starting because starting means structuring

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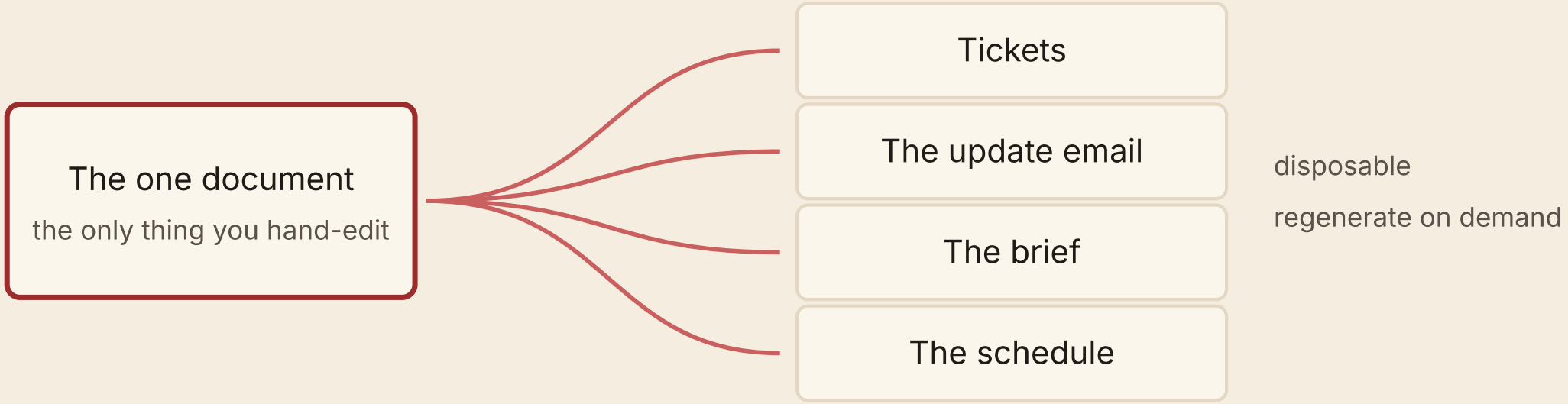
- You put off starting because starting means structuring
- Your best thinking happens away from the keyboard
- You have voice memos you never transcribed

MONDAY, 2PM

One document *earns the thinking*

PATTERN 2 · THE SINGLE HIGH-LEVERAGE ARTIFACT

Concentrate, then propagate



PATTERN 2 · WHY IT HOLDS

Shrink the surface you touch

Public roadmap drafts generated from the internal document get accepted at **70 to 80%**. One document carries enough signal to survive propagation.

You want to touch less of the work because everything you do touch should matter more.

ANTI-PATTERN IN THE ROOM: HAND-CORRECTING THE TICKET INSTEAD OF THE ROADMAP. DO IT TWICE AND THE TWO DOCUMENTS STOP AGREEING.

WHERE WE ARE

The week board

Mon AM
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Mon PM
One document

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Composability

Wed AM
Reactions

Wed PM
Priors · note-OS

Thu
Hoarding

Fri
The lens and the handoff

TUESDAY

The kickoff call and its *four descendants*

PATTERN 3 · COMPOSABILITY

Outputs become inputs



The skill you develop is context math: *is this enough to generate X?*

PATTERN 3 · COMPOSABILITY

Separate skills, reviewed handoffs

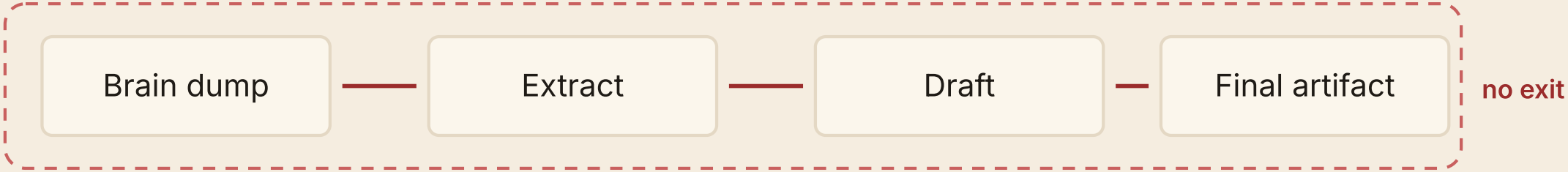


Run a skill. Read its output. Pass it on.

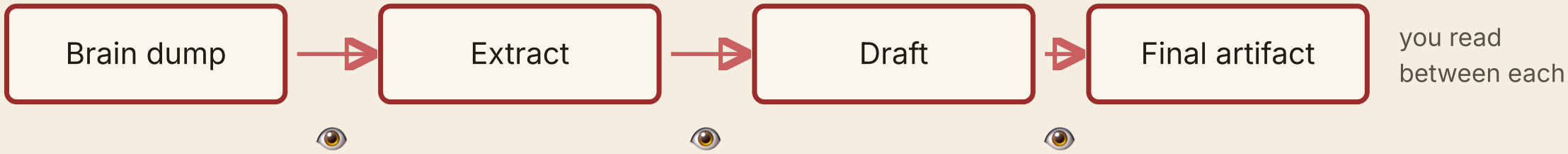
PATTERN 3 · THE CAUTION

Keep the stations separate

✗ One mega-skill, end to end



✓ Isolated skills, a human between each



The compounding is real. The mega-skill is the anti-pattern.

DEMO · TUESDAY

```
$ claude "notes from my latest meeting, then tasks from the notes"

  ⎿  meeting-obsidian → notes/2026-09-02-kickoff.md
  ⎿  notion-tasks           → 11 tasks, 4 owners
  ⎿  decision-log           → decisions/kickoff.md
```

Each skill writes a file. The next skill reads it. That is the whole interface.

WEDNESDAY, 9AM

You show someone the draft

and *record what they say*

PATTERN 4 · REACTIVE BRAIN-DUMPING

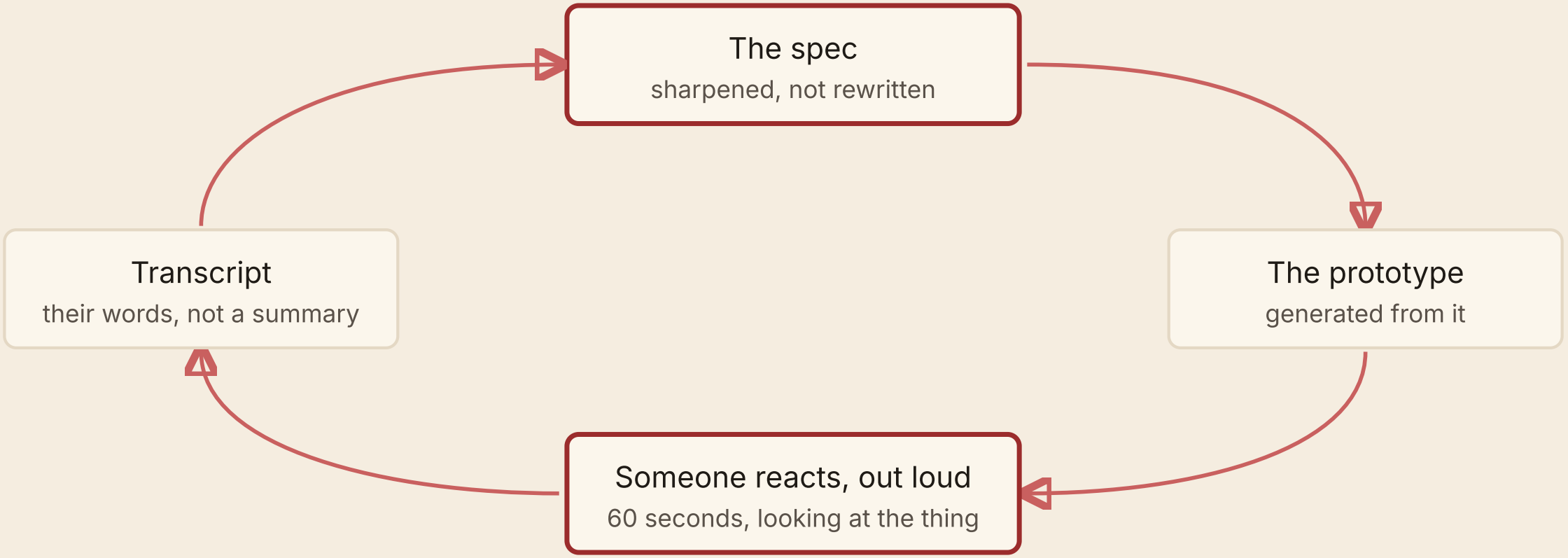
Reactions sharpen the spec



Show the prototype → record the reaction → update the spec

PATTERN 4 · REACTIVE BRAIN-DUMPING

Reactions are requirements



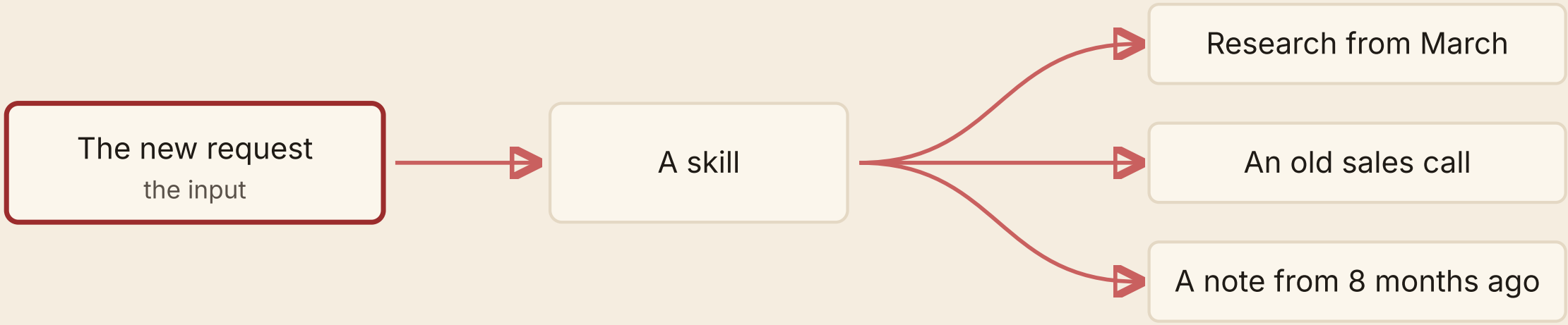
The signal is in the hesitation, not in the summary they send you later.

WEDNESDAY, 3PM

"Has someone here *solved this before?*"

PATTERN 5 · SURFACING THE PRIORS

The arrow runs backwards



Brain dumping goes from raw input to artifact. This one goes from the new thing back to the old things.

PATTERN 6 · STRUCTURED NOTE-OS

A filing system that runs itself

`claude-obsidian` layers an agent-maintained wiki on a plain Obsidian vault without touching the notes already there.

1. Drop a transcript, article, PDF or URL into a `.raw/` folder

Karpathy's writing on the one-note approach is where a lot of people started with this.

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2. Say **ingest**
3. The agent files each entity and concept as its own page and cross-links it into everything captured before
4. Every session ends by rewriting a 500-word hot-cache note of recent context

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WHERE WE ARE

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"The key idea is that coding agents mean we only ever need to figure out a useful trick once."

Simon Willison

PATTERN 7 · HOARDING WHAT YOU KNOW HOW TO DO

Workflows worth keeping

- **Matt Pocock’s skills repo** — a working directory, made public.

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Workflows worth keeping

- **Matt Pocock’s skills repo** — a working directory, made public.
- **Simon Willison’s tools repo** — over a hundred single-page HTML tools, linked to the commits and conversations that made them.

PATTERN 7 · WHEN TO SAVE A WORKFLOW

Three signals to freeze a workflow

1. You have pasted it more than twice

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Three signals to freeze a workflow

1. You have pasted it more than twice
2. It has more than one step
3. It should produce a file rather than a reply

PATTERN 8 · REFINEMENT

When the output is wrong, fix the skill



Put the correction in the spec. Regenerate the output.

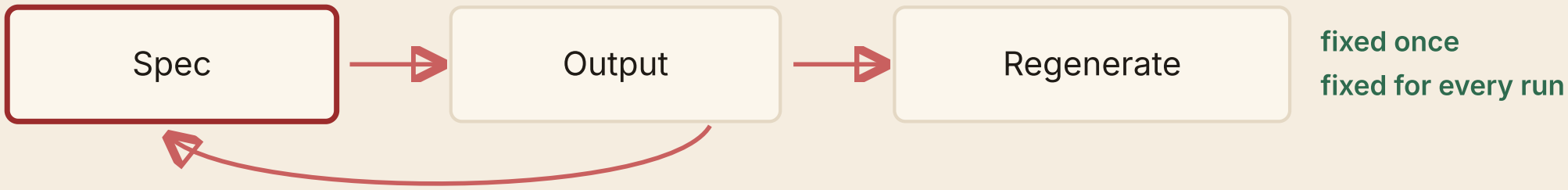
When the output is wrong, fix the skill

✗ Fix the output



spec goes stale
same mistake tomorrow

✓ Fix the spec



fixed once
fixed for every run

the correction goes back up

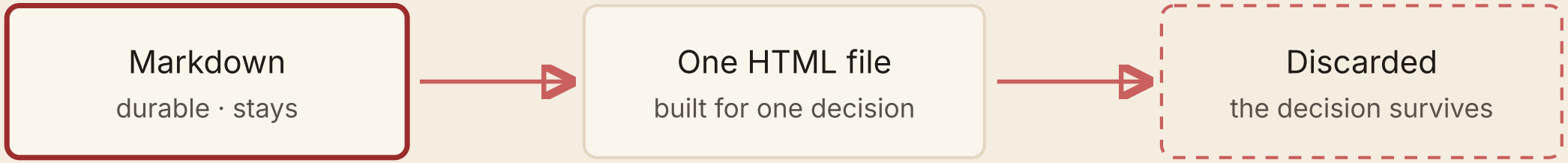
If the third revision didn't touch the spec, the spec is dead.

FRIDAY

Before it ships, *you have to see it*

PATTERN 9 · VIBE-CODED INTERMEDIARY ARTIFACTS

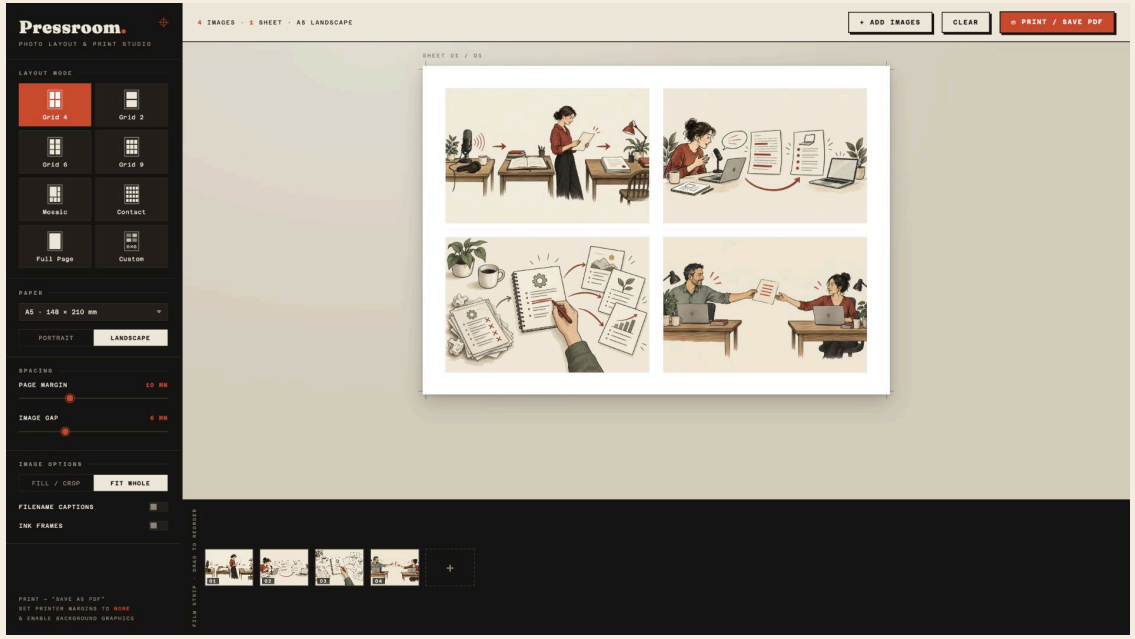
Markdown is the substrate, HTML is the lens



You build the thing to understand the thing.

A small interface for the task at hand

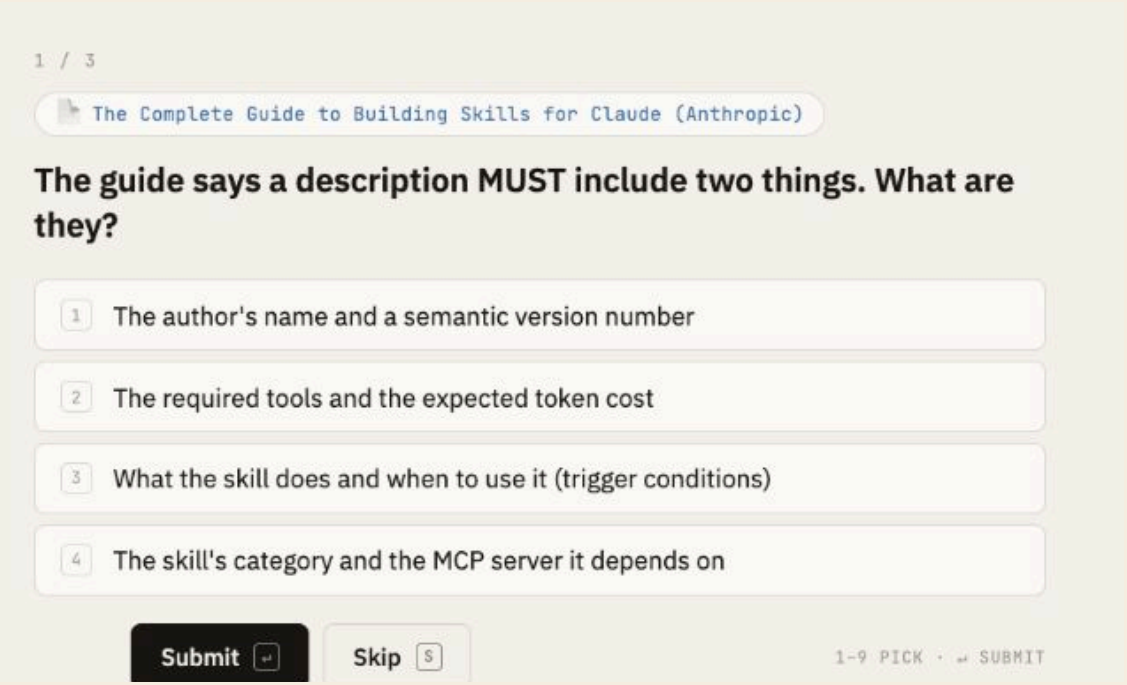
Print Studio



Arrange images. Preview the page. Print.

The interface helps you see and use the work.

Quiz generator



Turn source material into a practice session.

PATTERN 10 · SESSION-PERSISTING STATUS FILES

The bridge across context windows



File references, not code snippets — the next agent reads live code.

PATTERN 10 · SESSION-PERSISTING STATUS FILES

A file carries the context forward



- What I was working on

`/create_handoff` → `/resume_handoff`

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- What I was working on
- What changed — links to the live files
- What did not work

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PATTERN 10 · SESSION-PERSISTING STATUS FILES

A file carries the context forward



- What I was working on
- What changed — links to the live files
- What did not work
- What comes next

`/create_handoff` → `/resume_handoff`

THE FULL WEEK

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THE HONEST PART

Five ways this goes wrong

1. The mega-skill, one folder doing everything badly

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1. The mega-skill, one folder doing everything badly
2. Hand-correcting output, which reproduces the same mistake tomorrow
3. Reporting slop, where volume gets mistaken for insight
4. Trusting the score over your gut while the model grades its own homework
5. Downloading skills from strangers, which is arbitrary instructions running in your session

START MONDAY

One memo. One folder.

Pick the thing you pasted *three times* this month.